watch this if you want to get rich as f*ck in your 20s

Channel: Tim Luong · Published: Aug 06, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ruoRIaEpkxk Source: full transcript

📋 Executive Summary

Tim Luong distills his entire 20s — three failed businesses, a Wall Street internship, day trading, and an 8-figure business — into a three-part, order-specific playbook: health & mindset → money & skill-stacking → social design of life.

📑 Contents

🎯 The Three Games of Life (and Why Order Matters) 0:46

- There are **three games** you must optimize for in your 20s — and sequence matters critically
  - Game 1: Health & Mindset
  - Game 2: Money
  - Game 3: Social life / design of life
- Getting the order wrong leads to a miserable and stressful 30s and 40s
- Tim frames this as hard-won knowledge from 10 years of trials, millions lost, and many more millions made

💪 Game 1 — Health & Mindset: The Foundation 1:08

- Start as early as high school — don't wait for your 20s
  - Get in the gym to improve proportions and build confidence
  - Figure out what hairstyle works for you
  - Learn what clothes fit your body well
  - Address cosmetic issues early (Tim had bad acne in high school and fixed it)
- The goal is NOT to become a bodybuilder — it's to reach a **baseline of confidence**

    - Physical fitness produces confidence regardless of gender
    - Looking good and feeling good translates directly into willingness to take risk
- Tim's personal experience:
    - Once he was in shape, dressed well, and liked how he looked, he felt confident enough to pursue and take risks in life
    - Being insecure and worried about others' opinions is a direct blocker to pursuing the money game
- Core principle: health and mindset is the **fundamental pillar** — get it right first, then you can take unlimited swings at money

💰 Game 2 — Money: Take Risk Early and Stack Skills [3:04]

- Tim's full chronology of attempts (all at UCLA and shortly after):
    - Business #1 — Failed: chose the wrong co-founder
    - Business #2 — Failed: wasn't technical enough
    - 3-month coding bootcamp — learned coding wasn't for him
    - Landed a Wall Street internship — quickly realized it wasn't the right path
    - Rejected from UCLA's startup accelerator **twice**
    - Learned day trading — failed ~8 times before cracking it; day trading gave him freedom and capital to pursue bigger risks
    - Business #4 — **Succeeded**: built an **8-figure-a-year business**
    - Then started making content (his current pursuit)
- By age **24**, Tim had **$1 million** in his bank account, having started taking risk at 18
- Two things enabled him to persist through failure:
    - A strong health and mindset foundation
    - **Delusional self-belief** — the conviction that he could eventually figure it out
- Key mindset: you don't need to know HOW long it will take — it might be 1 year or 6 years; what matters is giving yourself enough "at-bats"
    - > "Eventually, if you get yourself enough at bats, it's going to work."
- The public only sees the success of day trading; they don't see the failed businesses, rejected accelerator applications, internships, and coding bootcamp that came before it

⏰ Why Starting Early Is a Non-Negotiable Advantage [5:01]

- Tim started at 18 (in college, skipping class to build companies) and hit $1M by 24
    - If he had started at 25–26 instead, with peer pressure and less runway, he believes he would have quit
- "Later never comes" — every person Tim knew in college who said they'd start a business after 2 years of work experience never did

  - He has witnessed this pattern with people smarter than him in virtually every dimension
- The dangerous trap for smart people:
  - Intelligence allows you to construct very convincing, logical reasons to delay
  - "I need to get work experience first" is a rationalization that feels responsible but is actually avoidance
- Starting early gives you **enough at-bats** to pivot repeatedly without running out of time or runway
  - Pivot, then pivot again, then pivot again — time is your most valuable asset in your 20s
- The do-it-for-a-year-and-go-back-to-a-job framing is wrong:
  - You don't know if it'll take 1 year or 6 years
  - Setting an artificial deadline guarantees you quit too early

🧠 The Real Reason Smart People Don't Take Risk 6:12

- The root cause is **fear of judgment from peers**, not lack of readiness or skill
  - Smart people don't want peers to see them fail publicly after college
  - Telling themselves "I need 2 years at a Wall Street firm or consulting firm" is socially safe cover
- Every friend Tim had in college told him starting a business was a **bad idea**
- The moment you eliminate the fear of peer judgment, you dramatically increase your likelihood of taking meaningful risk
- Tim's observation: every person he knows who didn't take the risk, deep down, didn't want to be judged by their peers
- People with **astronomical returns** took massive risk — risk by definition means embracing the unknown

🔧 Skill Stacking: The Hidden Mechanism Behind the Money 8:30

- Tim realized in hindsight that what he was actually doing was **skill stacking**
  - Definition: learning multiple skills that compound on top of each other and work in unison, making you uniquely valuable
- How skill stacking creates outsized outcomes:
  - Content creation alone = limited
  - Content creation + great product = big business potential
  - Content creation + great product + design = differentiated, potentially dominant business
- The Steve Jobs analogy:
  - Jobs differentiated Apple from Microsoft by applying a background in art and design to the same computing niche
  - Result: products that were "out of this world sleek"
  - The intersection of skills — not any single skill — created the breakthrough
- Tim's own skill stack (accumulated through failures):

    - Coding bootcamp → helped him find and evaluate his first developer for the successful business
    - Running Facebook ads for Business #3 → directly applied to getting clients for Business #4
    - Each failure taught him 1–2 new skills
- Skills Tim ultimately needed to run an 8-figure-a-year business:
    - Hiring people
    - Managing people
    - Closing sales on the phone
    - Building systems and processes
    - Running ads at scale (not just locally)
    - Writing webinars and VSLs
    - Building a CRM
- Core principle: **the game of money fundamentally comes down to how many skills you can stack and your rate of learning**
- The version of Tim who ran an 8-figure business was not special — he simply had enough compounded skill sets from enough at-bats

🌍 Game 3 — The Social Design of Life 11:40

- At **25 years old**, Tim had a business doing **$300K/month in revenue** — and was completely miserable
    - Gained weight ("fat") from stress
    - Hair was falling out
    - Couldn't sleep through the night
- Realization: money alone is not the point — you must also design a life you enjoy
    - What do you do for fun?
    - Are you actually healthy, not just technically working out?
    - Do you have friends you enjoy?
    - Are you experiencing your money, or just accumulating it?
- The money game is **infinite** — there will always be someone making more; it never ends
    - You must decide at some point: what is **enough**, so you stop sacrificing health and social life for incremental gains
- Building a real social circle:
    - You need **reliable friends on the same path** — motivated, driven people on their own journeys
    - Not people who need you, not people who use you
    - Litmus test: "If something dire happened at 3 a.m., could you call this person? Would they pick up and come help?"
- Living in your 20s:
    - Tim always wanted to live in New York, LA, Miami — and did it while young

    - It's possible in your 30s–50s but harder with family and kids, and simply not the same experience
- First 3–4 years of building: Tim didn't take a single day off — that grind is real and necessary early
    - But you must eventually shift to also investing in your social and personal life

🔁 The Regret Minimization Framework 13:10

- Framework: *"If I'm 80 years old looking back, would I regret not doing this one thing?"*
    - If the answer is yes → do it
- Tim applied it to the Wall Street internship vs. learning day trading decision:
    - "I can always get a Wall Street job after college — I just proved it by landing this internship."
    - "I can never go back and find out if day trading is real if I don't try it now."
    - Chose day trading → changed his life
- Applied it to starting businesses in college instead of going to class:
    - "I'm going to pass anyway. I don't need a 4.0. I will regret not having tried."
- Applied it to life experiences (cities, adventures):
    - Chose to live in the cities he always wanted while young, knowing it gets harder with age and family
- The framework resolves any "should I take this risk?" question by shifting the time horizon to your deathbed
    - Removes short-term peer pressure from the equation
    - Reframes failure as "at least I tried" rather than "I never even swung"